

Your Care Plan

Heart Failure

You are in the hospital for heart failure. Your heart does not pump as well as it should with this condition.

This handout gives you an idea of the stages you will go through on the way to getting better and leaving the hospital.

Many people can leave the hospital within 2 days after they are admitted. Other people need more time in the hospital. You may move through these steps faster or slower than shown here. You and your healthcare team will decide based on how you do each day.

Day 1



After You Are Treated in the Emergency Room:

- You may be taken to the ICU (intensive care unit) or a regular hospital room depending on the type of care you need.



Your Activity:

- You will rest in bed. You may be able to get out of bed. Ask your doctor or nurse about this.



Your Food & Fluids:

- You may have an IV line for fluids and medicines.
- You may be given low salt foods.
- You may be allowed only limited amounts of liquids.



Your Medicines:

- You may get one or more of these medicines:
 - Blood pressure medicine
 - Medicine to control your heartbeat
 - Medicine to remove extra fluid from your body (diuretic)
 - Other heart medicines

- Other medicines you normally take



Other Care:

- You will get blood tests.
- You will have an EKG (electrocardiogram).
- You may have a tube in your chest.
- You may get oxygen through a mask or a small nose piece.
- Your weight will be checked.
- You may have one or more tests that make pictures of what is happening inside your body. These may include:
 - Chest x-ray
 - Echo test (echocardiogram)

Day 2



Your Activity:

- You should be able to get up and move around more.



Your Food & Fluids:

- You may still have an IV line.
- You may be given low salt foods.
- Your doctor may change the amount of liquid you can drink.



Your Medicines:

- You may get one or more of these medicines:
 - Blood pressure medicine
 - Medicine to control your heartbeat
 - Medicine to remove extra fluid from your body (diuretic)
 - Other heart medicines

- Other medicines you normally take



Other Care:

- You may get blood tests.
- You may have another EKG.
- The tube in your chest may be removed.
- Some of your medicines and activities may change because of your illness.
Now is a good time to start learning about the changes you will need to make when you leave the hospital.
- You may be moved to a regular hospital room.
- Your weight will be checked.
- You may have one or more tests that make pictures of what is happening inside your body. These may include:
 - Chest x-ray

Day 3



Your Activity:

- You should be able to get up and move around more.



Your Food & Fluids:

- Your IV line may be removed today.
- You may be given low salt foods.



Your Medicines:

- You may get one or more of these medicines:
 - Blood pressure medicine
 - Medicine to control your heartbeat
 - Medicine to remove extra fluid from your body (diuretic)

- Other heart medicines
- Other medicines you normally take



Other Care:

- You may no longer need extra oxygen.
- Your weight will be checked.

Leaving the Hospital

- Most people are able to return home when they leave the hospital. Others move to a different type of healthcare setting to continue their recovery.
- You will be able to leave the hospital when:
 - Your test results are OK.
 - Your heartbeat is OK.
 - Your blood pressure is OK.
 - The swelling in your feet, ankles, or legs is down.
 - You are not having trouble breathing.
 - You are able to think clearly.
 - Your kidneys are working normally.
 - You are able to move around safely.
- When you leave the hospital you should have:
 - A list of all your medicines
 - Prescriptions for any new medicines you will need
 - A list of follow-up visits you will need
 - The information you need for your care at home
 - A plan for getting the care you need after you leave the hospital

This information is general in nature and may not apply to you or your condition. Talk to your doctor or nurse about how to best use this information and how to take care of your medical condition. Be sure to ask your doctor or nurse any questions you might have. This information sheet is not intended to provide or replace professional medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment.

Patient or Caregiver:

Signature: _____

Date: _____

Nurse:

Signature: _____

Date: _____